

Derbyshire Shared Care Pathology Guidelines

Management of Altered Bowel Habit/Diarrhoea

There are three categories of referral, but before doing so please check:

Has patient got a history of change in medication that can cause diarrhoea (especially PPI, SSRI)? If so, try withdrawal or substitution before referral.

When referring for Altered Bowel Habit without diarrhoea please undertake baseline investigations:

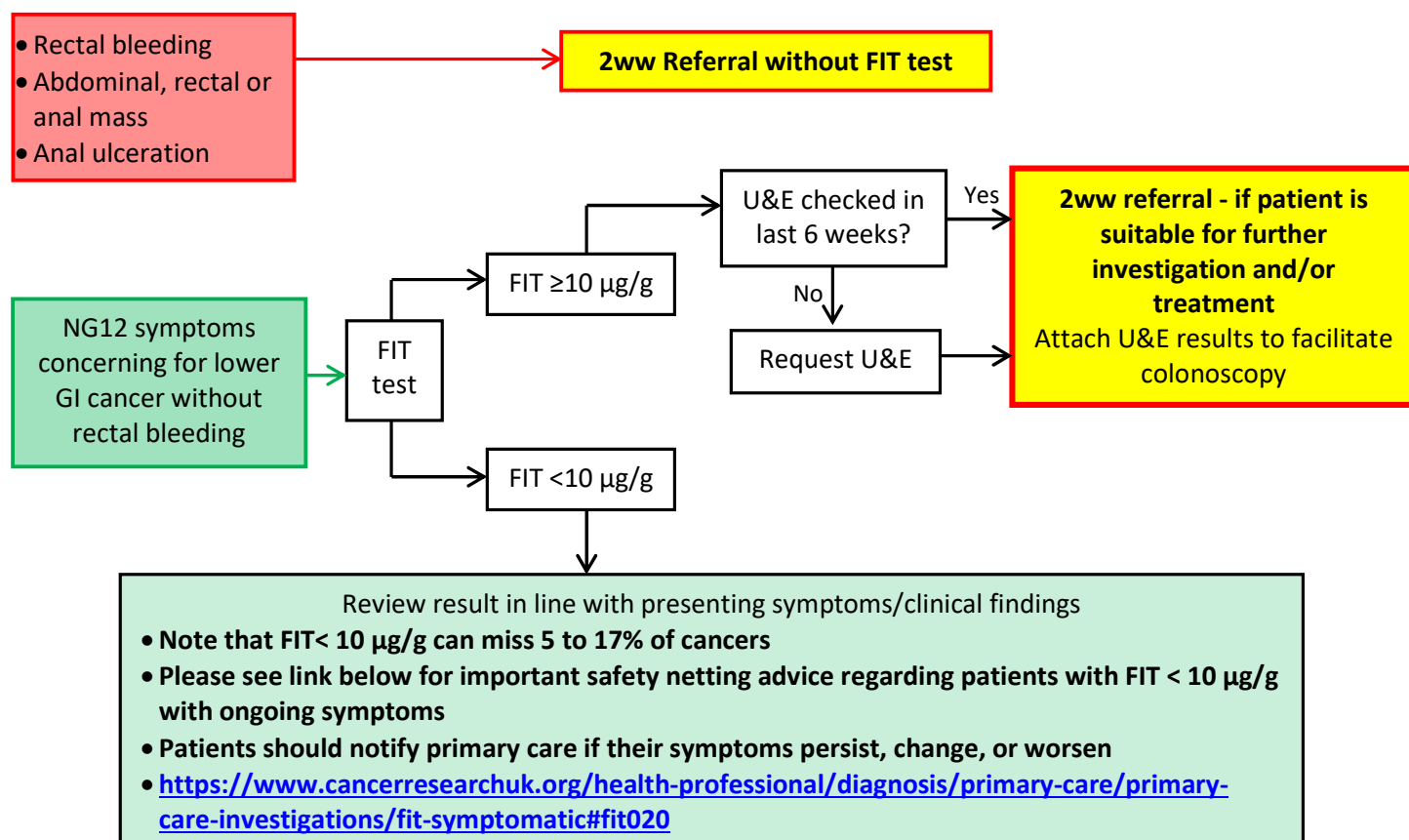
- FBC
- U&E
- LFT
- Calcium
- CRP

If patient has diarrhoea add on to the above tests:

- Coeliac serology
- Thyroid function tests
- Stool culture (and microscopy if recent foreign travel)

Three Referral Categories

Category A (Suspected Lower GI Cancer)



Category B (Organic Diarrhoea)

Any patient presenting with diarrhoea who has any of the following features:

Age less than 50 years with

- Weight loss
- Iron deficiency anaemia
- Tenesmus
- Strong family history of bowel cancer (in first degree relative aged <60)
- Abdominal mass
- PR bleeding
- Mass on PR

or patients of any age with,

- Bloody stools
- Frequent loose stools
- Incontinence
- Nocturnal diarrhoea
- Strong family history of IBD
- Raised CRP
- Positive tTG/IgA deficiency

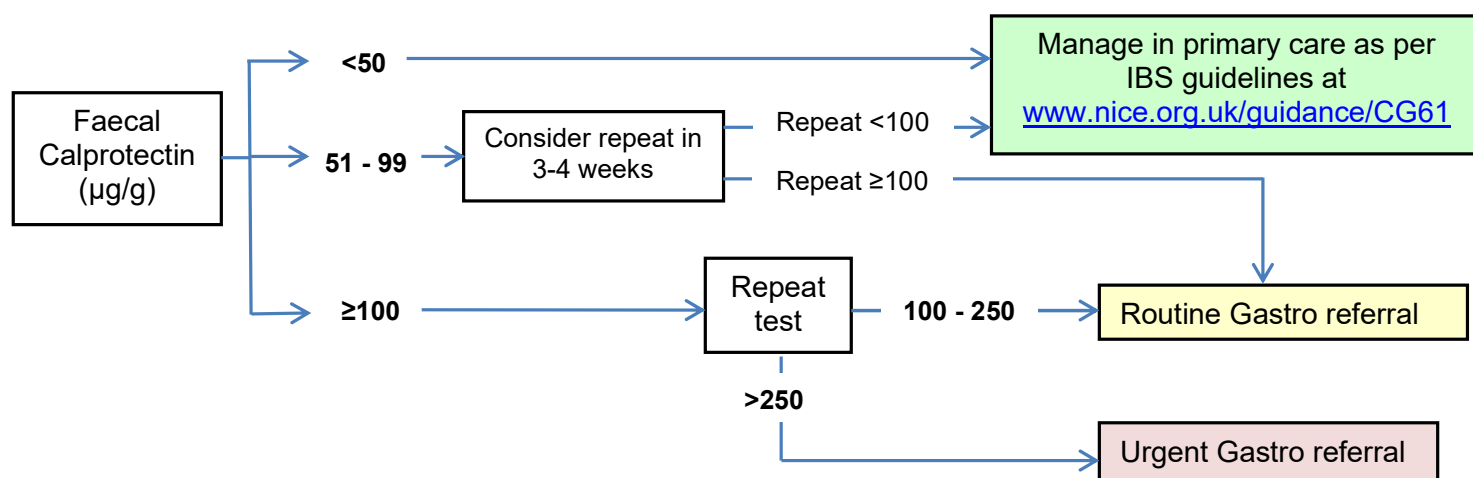
Action: Refer to Gastroenterology Department

NB. Urgent referral or emergency admission is recommended for patient who may have a severe colitis. Typical patients may have 6 or more bloody stools per day, fever, tachycardia and anaemia.

Category C (Probable IBS)

Altered bowel habit, abdominal pain or discomfort that is relieved by defaecation, bloating but in the absence of category A and B features and normal blood tests i.e. no anaemia nor raised CRP. (Note FIT < 10 µg/g does not exclude lower GI cancer in patients with ongoing symptoms - see category A).

- Use calprotectin to exclude IBD in patients <40yr if cancer is not suspected (morning sample)
- **Do not** carry out faecal calprotectin within 1 week of gastrointestinal infection (level will be raised)
- PPIs and NSAIDs can elevate calprotectin, consider stopping for 3 weeks before testing



References

Guidelines for the investigation of chronic diarrhoea in adults: British Society of Gastroenterology, 3rd edition. Arasaradnam RP, et al. Gut 2018;1–20. doi:10.1136/gutjnl-2017-315909

Document title	Management of altered bowel habit		
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	V3 Nov 2016	Dr B Norton, Dr P Blackwell, Mrs H Seddon	Routine review
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Approval	Date	Name(s)	Designation
Secondary Care UHDB	03.03.26	Dr B Norton	Consultant Gastroenterologist
Secondary Care CRH	02.03.26	Dr D Elphick	Consultant Gastroenterologist
Primary Care	03.03.26	Dr P Blackwell	GP
Laboratory (Derbyshire Pathology)	05.03.26	Ms S Knowles	Consultant Clinical Scientist